

Hansi Udapola

UX Researcher & Developer | XR-AI

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WORK EXPERIENCE

Postdoctoral UX Researcher & Developer | Oct.2025 – present

JIX Reality Pvt. Ltd. | Christchurch, New Zealand

- Conduct stakeholder interviews and client meetings to gather and refine system requirements.
- Identify key challenges, user pain points, and prioritise features for prototype development.
- Develop rapid prototypes (low- to high-fidelity) to translate concepts into testable solutions.
- Lead design reviews with stakeholders and prepare evaluation-ready prototypes.
- Mentor interns, providing technical guidance to ensure timely achievement of project milestones.
- Evaluate emerging frameworks, tools, and AI/XR platforms to support innovation.

HCI Research Fellow | Nov.2023 – Feb.2024

JIX Reality Pvt. Ltd. | Christchurch, New Zealand

- Designed user studies following UCD principles, including research plans and study protocols.
- Conducted literature reviews to develop human–AI interaction design guidelines.
- Developed feasibility study plans and reported findings with actionable future directions.

Tutor – UX Engineering | Feb.2023 – Jun.2025

Victoria University of Wellington | Wellington, New Zealand

- Guided students in developing personas, user workflows, and journey maps, and supported prototype evaluation across fidelity levels.
- Assessed assignments and examinations, providing clear, criteria-based feedback on UX principles.
- Mentored students in UX methods (heuristic evaluation, cognitive walkthroughs, usability testing) and supported interpretation of findings into design improvements.

University Lecturer | Mar.2017 – May.2021

University of Kelaniya | Colombo, Sri Lanka

- Delivered lectures and facilitated tutorials, seminars, and lab sessions, fostering interactive learning environments.
- Designed and assessed coursework, providing academic guidance and student support.
- Contributed to curriculum development, course planning, and preparation of specialised learning materials.
- Supervised honours students and supported teaching staff in academic delivery.
- Collaborated with the Faculty of Health to analyse over 6 million diary entries, contributing to evidence-based research outcomes.

Mobile App Developer | Feb.2016 – Aug.2016
INOVA IT Systems Pvt. Ltd. | Colombo, Sri Lanka

- Designed wireframes and user interfaces based on SRS documents, translating requirements into structured visual layouts.
- Developed Android user interfaces using Android Studio in alignment with Google Material Design guidelines.
- Developed mobile applications using Android (Java) to meet functional requirements.
- Conducted unit testing, documentation, and supported beta release processes.
- Prepared feasibility study plans and reported insights with recommendations.

EDUCATION

PhD in Computer Science – Specialized in Human Computer Interactions | Mar.2021 – Feb.2026
Victoria University of Wellington | Wellington, New Zealand
Thesis: Role of Conversational Virtual Characters in Improving Social Interactions of Adolescents in Collaborative Games in Social VR

B.Sc. Honours in Computer Science | Mar.2013 – Mar.2017
University of Kelaniya | Colombo, New Zealand
Research Project: Braille Messenger: Adaptive learning based non-visual touch screen text input for the blind community using braille
GPA: 3.96 out of 4.0 (WES certified) | Gold Medalist | Dean List

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Research Methods	Interviews, focus groups, surveys/questionnaires (Qualtrics), observations, Telemetry
Evaluation Methods	Usability testing, heuristic evaluation, cognitive walkthrough, prototype evaluation (low/high fidelity), User Experience, Playtesting
Study & Experiment Design	Within-subject, between-subjects, mixed factorial (within + between), partially nested designs, A/B testing
Visual Tools for Insights and Decision Making	Affinity diagramming, sociograms (multi-human-AI interaction behaviour analysis), Priority matrix, impact vs, effort diagrams,
UX Tools & Frameworks	Personas, user interaction workflows, journey maps, wireframing
Data Analysis	Quantitative data analysis, descriptive & inferential statistics, data visualisation, Tableau, R, Python, SQL, Qualitative data analysis, thematic analysis, content analysis
Research Tools	NVivo, Qualtrics, Miro, RStudio
AI/ML Platforms & Services	OpenAI, Huggingface, Kaggle, Azure Cognitive, Copilot, Cursor.ai, ClaudeAI, Anttigravity, Figma Make
Prototyping	Low/high-fidelity prototyping, pen & paper, Figma, ShapeXR, Unity functional prototypes, XR/VR, Vibe Coding

FEATURED PROJECTS

Social Buddy: AI-Powered NPC for Social Virtual Reality

- Developed a conversational virtual agent in Social VR to support engagement for adolescents with social interaction difficulties based on insights from mixed method approaches in Human-centered designs.

Skills:

- Hybrid design approaches for identifying requirements. Conducting Interviews and surveys via Qualtrics, Analysis for identifying requirements, co-design with adolescents over several sessions through brainstorming sessions.
- Usability Testing with Jakob Nielsen's Usability
- Comprehensive evaluation study to validate the designed mechanics/features in the prototype.

Mixed Reality Visual Impairment Simulation Prototype

- Developed prototypes to supporting inclusive design by simulating visual impairments and addressing stakeholder needs.

Skills:

- Conducted stakeholder meetings focusing on empathy and requirement identification.
- Designed and developed prototypes to meet identified accessibility and stakeholder requirements.
- Facilitated demonstrations and design review sessions with stakeholders to gather feedback.
- Developed multiple prototypes to simulate a range of visual impairments, enabling informed and inclusive design decisions.

ColorFill App

- Designed a playful, freemium "color-by-number" mobile app for iOS and Android, balancing an engaging gamified user experience.

Skills:

- Based on different persona various features were designed and developed (In progress).
- Developed high-fidelity Figma prototypes (Figma Make) that translated complex client requirements into an intuitive interface featuring.

HONOURS & AWARDS

- **Appreciation Letter for Outstanding Performance - HCI** - Victoria University of Wellington
Received an appreciation letter from the Head of School for receiving an A+ for HCI course. 2021
 - **Batch Top - General Convocation 2017** - University of Kelaniya
Memorial gold medal for receiving the highest marks of the batch. GPA: 3.96/4.00 2017
 - **Computer Science Gold Medal - General Convocation 2017** - University of Kelaniya
Gold medal for receiving the highest marks for Computer Science. SGPA: 4.0/4.0 2017
 - **Best Undergraduate Research Project** - Computer Science Category - Sri Lanka
Sri Lanka Association for the Advancement of Science (SLAAS) 2017
 - **Dean List - Academic Excellence** - University of Kelaniya
Nominated for the Dean's List, Faculty of Science. Yearly (2 semesters) YGPA: 4.0/4.0 2015/2016
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